





Takeaways

- **Ajith Kumar, 27, a temple watchman in Sivaganga, dies in police custody**
- **Cops first claim he had a seizure while trying to flee**
- **Video of cop in mufti beating Ajith (left) belies this, backs post-mortem**
- **Stalin expresses personal regret as Oppn raises storm**

▶ TAMIL NADU

BLOW BY BLOW ACCOUNTING

One more custodial death, this time of a theft suspect, puts the spotlight back on a grim reality: Tamil Nadu's political licence for police violence

ogy phone call to Ajith's mother by chief minister M.K. Stalin came alongside a promise of compensation and a government job to his family.

CAST THE FIRST STONE

The Opposition was still quick to seize the moment. AIADMK general secretary and ex-CM Edappadi K. Palaniswami called Ajith's death a case of "police murder". But as civil society activists point out, that critique is made politically fraught by his own party's flawed record. The EPS-led AIADMK regime was the one in the dock when the Sathankulam custodial deaths triggered nationwide protests and media scrutiny in 2020. Now, as it speaks in prosecutorial tones, it has for company (or as competition) actor-politician Vijay, who, too, called on the victim's family and promised support. The DMK, in turn, sought to underline its sense of accountability with the CM's personal outreach—minister T.R.B. Rajaa called it "a first in Tamil Nadu's political history". It's clear the overhang of the 2026 assembly election is setting the tone for all the politics, and Ajith's death has become a symbolic battleground.

Its physical details fit an old, depressing template. A temple watchman in Thiruppuvanam, Ajith was called in on June 27 for questioning in connection with a jewellery theft. Not formally arrested, nor named in an FIR, it appears he was taken to a cowshed near the temple—where the stolen items were allegedly hidden—and brutally assaulted. Next day, he was declared "brought dead" at a hospital. Police initially claimed Ajith had suffered an epileptic seizure while trying to escape. That version began to unravel after a video surfaced online, showing an officer striking Ajith as he knelt on the ground. The post-mortem revealed over 40 injuries, including blunt force trauma, and internal bleeding. The courts later observed grimly: "Even an ordinary murderer would not have caused these many injuries."

Civil society voices warn the rot is "systemic and deeply entrenched". The twin custodial deaths of Sathankulam in 2020, too, had been handed over to the CBI—but only after public pressure and judicial intervention. It's still pending. The National Crime Records Bureau counts five custodial deaths in Tamil Nadu in 2022. But the Madurai-based group People's Watch documented 11, including one of a 17-year-old. "There's no standalone law to prevent torture. Even the courts hesitate to name it for what it is," says I. Aseervatham of People's Watch. "Even senior IPS officers escape accountability." The assistant superintendent accused in the Ambasamudram case is off suspension and regularly skips proceedings—the last time in May 2025.

Ajith's story joins a grim continuum that links up with the brutal police crackdowns seen during the Veerappan manhunt decades ago. "What we need is mandatory human rights education across all police ranks," says Aseervatham. Else, Ajith's name won't be the last to join Tamil Nadu's growing ledger of custodial deaths. ■